

THE PLAN GUIDE

5 questions to ask before your next *real estate move.*

A short field guide for anyone thinking about buying, selling, or investing. The questions inside are the ones I walk every client through before we even start looking at houses. They take 15 minutes. They'll save you months.

BEFORE YOU START

Most real estate decisions get made *in reaction*.

A landlord raises rent. A baby is on the way. Rates move. A house pops up that looks perfect. The moment shows up, and the decision gets made fast, before the thinking has caught up.

The clients I have seen feel calmest through a move, and end up with the most equity on the other side, almost always start with the same thing. Clarity. They sit with the questions first, then go shop, not the other way around.

These are the five I walk every client through before we even start looking at houses. Sit with them. They take 15 minutes. They will save you months.

How to use this guide

Read all five. Try the exercise at the end of each one. Bring the answers, or the questions you cannot answer, to whoever you trust to help you decide. Or bring them to me on a 30 minute strategy session. There is no commitment.

01

QUESTION ONE · THE FIVE YEAR VIEW

What does your life look like *five years from now?*

WHY IT MATTERS

The trap most people fall into is shopping for the life they have right now. Kids change. Jobs change. Routines change. The best moves are the ones built around where you are going, not where you are today.

A two bedroom condo near the office is the right answer for a current life that may be the wrong answer for a five year life. The opposite is also true. A bigger home further out can solve for a future that has not arrived yet, at the cost of a present that is still happening.

TRY THIS

Write one paragraph describing a regular Tuesday in your life five years from now. Then ask whether this move supports that picture or fights it.

02

QUESTION TWO · THE REAL REASON

What is this move *actually solving for*?

WHY IT MATTERS

There is usually a surface answer. "We need more space." And there is a real answer. "We are tired of feeling like our home does not match our life." The real answer is the one that should drive the decision. The surface answer is the one most people optimize for.

Optimizing for the surface answer can land you in a home that solved the visible problem and missed the actual one. More square footage in a town that drains you. A bigger investment in a market that does not fit your strategy. The right house for the wrong reason is still the wrong house.

TRY THIS

Write down the surface answer. Then ask yourself "and what would that give us?" three times. The third answer is usually the real one.

03

QUESTION THREE · THE COST OF WAITING

What is the real cost of waiting *versus moving now?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Both directions have a price. Equity gained, equity missed, rate locked in, rate left on the table, inventory tightening or loosening, life moments that do not pause. Waiting can be the right call. It just should not be the default.

The honest comparison is not "now versus the perfect time." It is "now versus twelve months from now with the information you actually have today." Some markets reward patience. Some punish it. The only way to know which kind of moment you are in is to actually write both columns down.

TRY THIS

List three costs of moving now. List three costs of waiting twelve months. Look at both lists honestly.

04

QUESTION FOUR · THE BIGGER MONEY PICTURE

What does your money need to do *besides this transaction?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Real wealth is built by the people who do not pour every dollar into one move. Reserves matter. Flexibility matters. The next opportunity matters. The mortgage you can technically afford and the mortgage that lets your life keep working are usually two different numbers.

A purchase that is right on paper can still be wrong for your life if it leaves nothing left for the kids, the next investment, the small business idea, or the six months of runway you would want if anything changed at work. The number that matters is not the maximum. It is the one that leaves room.

TRY THIS

Beyond the down payment and monthly payment, what does your money need to be free to do over the next three to five years?

05

QUESTION FIVE · THE FUTURE CHECK

What would have to be true for this to feel like the *right decision* a year from now?

WHY IT MATTERS

Future you knows things current you does not. Borrow a little of that perspective before you sign anything. If you can clearly picture what "right" looks like twelve months out, you will know whether this house, this price, or this timing actually gets you there.

The decisions that feel right a year later usually share something in common. They were not the most impulsive option. They were not the most pressured option. They were the one that lined up with a clear picture of what success was going to look like, written down before the closing date.

TRY THIS

Finish this sentence. "A year from now, I will know this was the right move because ____."

READY WHEN YOU ARE

Want to talk any of these *through with me?*

These are not the only questions worth asking. They are the ones I have watched make the biggest difference for the clients who end up calmest and most confident in their move. If you want to walk through any of them with me, that is literally what a strategy session is for.

Book a strategy session

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Krista Recker Properties

Strategy first. Decisions backed by data.